

Write an interpretation for a chart

Activity · Visualizations & Interpretation · ~20 min

Before you start

- ☐ You have a chart in your folder (built manually or via the AI)
- ☐ You have the *Reading a viz* reference handout next to you — the six-step framework

Why this matters

A chart on its own is just a picture. The **interpretation text** is what turns the picture into something a decision-maker can act on. The job of this handout is to walk you through writing that text — using the same six-step framework you just learned.

The structure

For every chart you put on a slide, your interpretation has **three parts**:

1. **A clear title** — the message in one sentence. Not "ANC1 results" — but "*ANC1 has dropped 12% in the Northern Region since Q1*".
2. **What you see** — describe the chart in plain words. Trends, magnitudes, anomalies.
3. **What it means** — the so-what. Why does this matter for service delivery? What action would it prompt?

Worked example

Title: *Northern Region ANC1 dropped 12% in Q1 2026 vs Q1 2025.*

What you see: Across the Northern Region, ANC1 monthly volumes fell from ~8,500 to ~7,500. The drop is concentrated in three districts (X, Y, Z) — facilities in the rest of the region are flat.

What it means: A 12% drop is large enough to be programmatic, not a data-quality artefact. The three driving districts need a follow-up — supportive supervision visits, plus a check on the data quality scores for those facilities.

Steps

1. Walk the six steps out loud

Before writing anything, talk through the chart with a teammate using the *Reading a viz* framework: indicator, level & period, what's being compared, values, what stands out, so what.

2. Write the title

Lead with the **message**, not a description. If a director read only the title, would they understand the finding?

3. Write "what you see"

Describe the chart in 1–3 sentences. Numbers, trends, comparisons. **No interpretation yet** — just the facts visible on the chart.

4. Write "what it means"

The so-what. **What action would this prompt?** Be specific. *"Supportive supervision visits in 3 districts"* — not *"improve performance"*.

5. Add to your slide

In the Slide Decks tab, open your deck, add the chart, paste your text alongside it.

Pitfalls to avoid

- **Title as description** — *"Coverage results"* tells the reader nothing. Use the headline.
- **Mixing facts and interpretation** — keep "what you see" facts-only. The reader needs to trust the description before the interpretation.
- **Vague action** — if the so-what doesn't name a person or a next step, it's not actionable yet.

What's next

The next handout shows how the **AI Assistant can draft this interpretation for you** — and how to verify and refine what it gives you.